The Measure of Being

Reflections on Reality, Choice, and Becoming.

DONOVAN LO

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Reflections on Reality, Choice, and Becoming

Donovan Lo

LUCID METHODS

Singapore

Selected Preview

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This preview contains selected excerpts from *The Measure of Being: Reflections on Reality, Choice, and Becoming*.

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A Note About This Preview

The Measure of Being began as an attempt to make sense of questions that rarely have simple answers.

Why do we judge ourselves by standards we cannot always see?
Why do good decisions sometimes lead to bad outcomes?
Why do certain lessons seem to return until we finally understand them?
And how do we learn to live with greater clarity when certainty is never guaranteed?

This preview brings together selected passages from different parts of the book. They are not intended to provide a complete argument or a condensed version of the whole. Instead, they offer a glimpse into some of the ideas, questions, and frameworks explored throughout its pages.

You may agree with some of them. You may question others.

That is part of the purpose.

This book was not written to tell you how to live. It was written to offer another way of looking at the things we often take for granted — reality, choice, emotion, worth, and the person we are becoming.

If something in these pages causes you to pause, reconsider an assumption, or see an experience differently, then perhaps the reflection has already begun.

Donovan Lo
Author, The Measure of Being

CHAPTER ONE

THE WORLD OF PROBABILITY

Why Do People Suffer When Reality Does Not Match Expectations?

One of the first illusions life dismantled was my belief in certainty.

When we are young, we often believe life follows simple rules.

Study hard and success will follow.
Work hard and you will be rewarded.
Be kind and people will treat you well.
Make good decisions and good things will happen.

These beliefs are comforting because they suggest that if we understand the rules, we can control the outcomes.
Life eventually teaches us otherwise.

Good people experience misfortune.
Dishonest people sometimes prosper.
Relationships fail despite genuine effort.
Carefully planned careers take unexpected turns.
Healthy individuals fall ill.
Unprepared individuals stumble into opportunity.

At first, this feels unfair. We become frustrated because life does not unfold as expected.

Yet the older I became, the more I wondered whether life was really the problem—or whether the problem was my expectation that it should be predictable.

> *Life never promised certainty.*
> *I was the one who expected it.*

Perhaps life has always been a world of probabilities. That realisation quietly changed the way I understood it.

Decisions and Outcomes

One of the most liberating lessons I have learned is that decisions and outcomes are related.
But they are not the same thing.

Good decisions increase the probability of good outcomes.
Poor decisions increase the probability of poor outcomes.
Yet probability is never certainty.

This distinction may appear obvious.
Yet much of our frustration comes from forgetting it.

We often judge a decision solely by its outcome.

When things go well, we assume the decision was good.
When things go badly, we assume it was poor.

Life is rarely so simple.

A careful driver may still be involved in an accident.

A talented candidate may still be rejected from a job.
A thoughtful investment may still lose money.

Likewise, a reckless decision may occasionally produce a fortunate result.

One example stayed with me.

Imagine helping a friend through one of the most difficult periods of their life.
You listen.
You encourage.
You give your time without expecting anything in return.

Many people would consider that a good decision.
Yet life offers no guarantee that the friendship will grow stronger.

Sometimes the friend recovers...
And quietly disappears without even saying goodbye.

The outcome can feel painful.
But it does not necessarily mean helping was the wrong decision.

A decision should be judged by the information, values and intentions available when it was made.

Outcomes are influenced by many factors beyond our control, including other people's choices.

The quality of a decision cannot always be measured by the result that eventually follows.

> *We are not responsible for*
> *controlling every outcome.*
> *We are responsible for making*
> *the best decisions we can with*
> *the knowledge we have at the time.*

One distinction quietly changed how I looked at almost every outcome in life.

A little further into the chapter...

What if every decision does not lead to one future,
but to many possible futures?

Selected from

Chapter One
The World of Probability

Possibility defines what can happen.
Probability estimates what
is more likely to happen.

The Distribution of Possibility

When I was younger, I imagined the future as though it were already written.

There would be one outcome.
One path.
One ending waiting to be discovered.

Life slowly convinced me otherwise.

Every decision creates not one future,
but many possible futures.
Some are highly likely.
Others are merely possible.

Imagine standing at the centre of a bell curve.
The highest point represents the outcome that is most likely to occur.
As we move away from the centre, the outcomes become progressively less likely.
Yet they never become impossible.

This is how I have come to see life.

Every decision creates a distribution of possibilities rather than a single predetermined result.

The purpose of making good decisions is not to guarantee success.
It is to shift the entire curve.

A wise decision moves the peak toward more desirable outcomes.
A poor decision shifts it in the opposite direction.
Yet uncertainty always remains.

Even the best decision cannot eliminate unlikely events.
A careful driver may still encounter an accident caused by someone else.
A healthy person may unexpectedly become ill.
A business built with integrity may still fail because of circumstances beyond its control.
Likewise, a careless decision may occasionally produce a fortunate result.

These exceptions do not invalidate the principle.
They remind us that life is governed by probability rather than certainty.

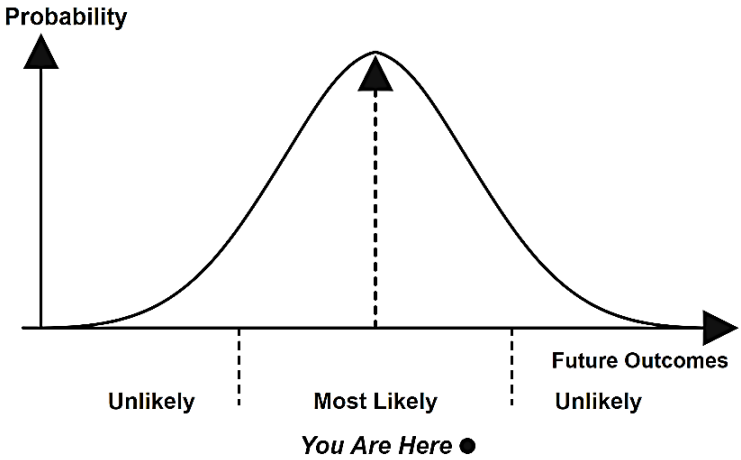
Once I understood this, many disappointments became easier to accept.
Success no longer proved every decision was right.
Failure no longer meant every decision was wrong.

The quality of a decision lies not in whether it guarantees the outcome we hoped for, but in whether it increased the likelihood of moving toward the life we wished to build.

That is all any decision can ever do.
It shifts probability.
It never abolishes uncertainty.

Every future begins as
a collection of possibilities.
We cannot eliminate uncertainty,
but we can shape the odds.

Figure 2. The Bell Curve of Possibility



Every decision begins with many possible futures rather than a single predetermined outcome. Although we cannot control which possibility ultimately becomes reality, our decisions influence which outcomes become more or less likely.

Selected from

Chapter Two
The Invisible Ruler

Every meaningful decision we make involves comparison.

We compare prices before making a purchase.
We compare routes before beginning a journey.
We compare job offers before accepting employment
We compare schools before deciding where to study.
We compare homes before deciding where to live.
We compare opinions before deciding what to believe.

Even when choosing friends, partners or careers, comparison quietly guides our decisions.

Comparison is one of the fundamental ways human beings make sense of the world.

Why would we suddenly stop comparing when evaluating ourselves?

The truth is that almost everyone compares themselves to others.

The student compares grades.
The employee compares salaries.
The athlete compares performance.
The parent compares children.
The entrepreneur compares results.

The problem is not comparison.
The problem is refusing to accept what comparison implies.

Over the years, I developed a simple mental model that helped me understand this.

If comparison is unavoidable,
then something must be doing the comparing.
Over time, I came to realise that each of us carries an invisible ruler.

The Invisible Ruler

Imagine a ruler that stretches from 0 to 100.

Not a ruler for height or weight.
A ruler for traits that are difficult to measure directly.

The ruler measures far more than wealth or achievement.
It measures beauty.
Intelligence.
Kindness.
Courtesy.
Discipline.

Leadership.
Empathy.
Wisdom.
Confidence.
Humour.
Success.
Even happiness.
Almost every intangible human quality can be imagined somewhere along this scale.

Different people use different rulers.
Many of us change rulers without even realising it.

> *We do not merely compare ourselves with others. We measure ourselves using rulers we cannot see.*

Now imagine placing yourself on that ruler.
Not according to objective reality,
but according to your honest perception.

Suppose I believe I am around the 75th percentile in analytical thinking.
What does that mean?
It means that among the people I encounter, I

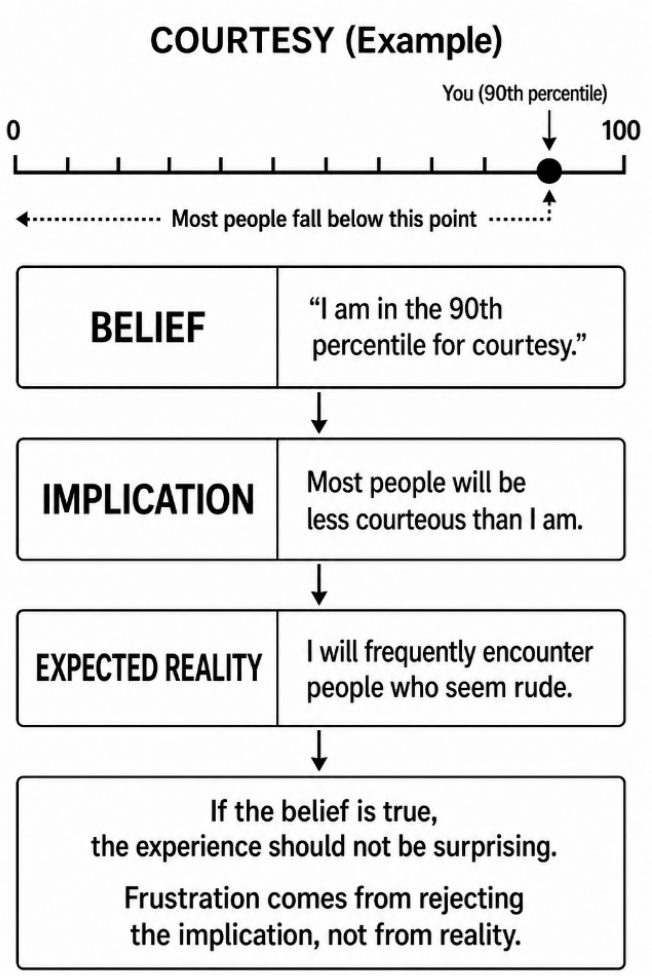
perceive myself to be stronger than roughly three-quarters of them in that particular trait.

Whether my assessment is accurate is not the point.
The point is that I have placed myself somewhere on the ruler.
Everyone does.
Most people simply do not realise it.

The moment we place ourselves on the ruler, we must also accept what that position implies.
The ruler is invisible.
So too are the scales upon it.
Yet we behave as though they were objective.

The ruler does not measure reality itself.
It measures how we perceive reality
and shapes what we expect from ourselves and from others.

Figure 3. The Invisible Ruler



Every comparison depends upon a ruler, even when that ruler remains unseen. The standards we adopt quietly shape our perception of success, failure, fairness, and ultimately, ourselves.

Selected from

Chapter Three
The Curse Of Foreknowledge

CHAPTER THREE

THE CURSE OF FOREKNOWLEDGE

Why do people sometimes reject the very knowledge that could have protected them?

There is a peculiar pattern I have observed throughout life.

Sometimes the people who prevent disasters receive the least recognition.
Not because they failed.
But because they succeeded.

The Disaster That Never Happened

Several years ago, I was invited to lead a charity that was approaching the renewal of its charitable status.

Almost immediately, I realised the organisation faced far greater challenges than I had expected.

Its financial records were in disarray.
Important regulatory requirements had not been followed consistently.

The external auditor was considering resigning from the engagement.

Without a successful audit, the charity risked failing to renew its charitable status.

> *Most people saw a deadline.*
> *I saw the chain of events waiting behind it.*

I met with the external auditor and asked them to give the organisation one final opportunity.
I explained that a failed audit would damage not

only the charity's reputation but also the confidence of everyone involved.

Then the real work began.
I personally reconstructed an
entire year's worth of financial records and
worked closely with the auditors
to resolve every outstanding issue.

I wrote to the Commissioner of Charities,
acknowledging our shortcomings and
explaining the circumstances honestly.

It required an enormous amount of work.
It also required cooperation, patience,
and a measure of good fortune.

Eventually, the audit was completed.
The charity successfully renewed its charitable status.

To most people, the crisis had passed.
Some even began to believe the financial controls had been unnecessarily strict.

After all, nothing bad had happened.

Yet that was precisely the point.
Nothing bad had happened because those controls

had been restored before the situation became irreversible.

As time passed, some board members gradually returned to the very practices that had placed the organisation at risk in the first place.

The danger had disappeared from memory because the danger itself had been prevented.

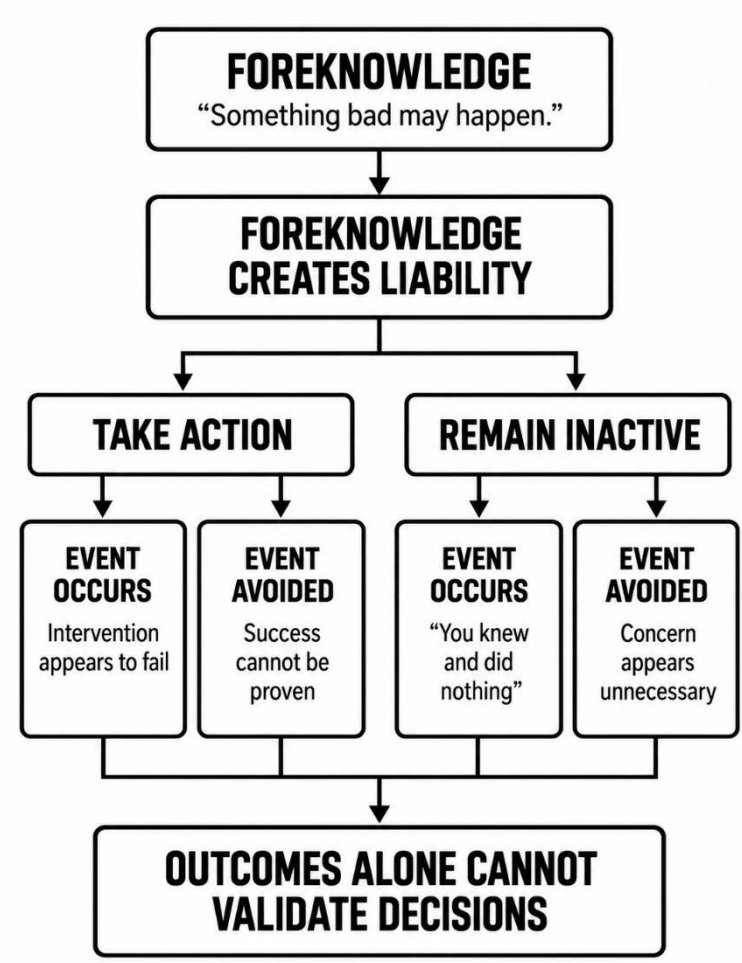
That experience taught me something I have never forgotten.
Successful prevention often erases the evidence that prevention was ever necessary.

When people forget the crisis, they also forget why the safeguards that prevented it were necessary.

What the Experience Taught Me

At first, I found the experience deeply frustrating. Surely anyone who had witnessed how close we came to losing the charity's status would understand why the financial controls mattered.

Figure 4. The Curse of Foreknowledge



Every act of prevention changes the future it seeks to avoid. When the anticipated problem never appears, the value of foreknowledge often becomes invisible, making successful prevention easy to misunderstand and difficult to appreciate.

The Four Paths

Most people assume foreknowledge creates only two possibilities.
You were right.
Or you were wrong.
Reality is far more complicated.
Once awareness appears, four paths emerge.

Path A1 — You Act and Harm Still Occurs

You intervene.
You warn others.
You attempt prevention.
The feared outcome occurs anyway.

Now another possibility appears.
Did your intervention fail?
Did it contribute to the outcome?
Did it alter behaviour in unexpected ways?
Did it create unintended consequences?

The attempt to prevent harm may itself become part of the explanation.

The person who acted can become
the person blamed.

Path A2 — You Act and Harm Does Not Occur

At first glance, this appears to be success.
Yet success creates a new problem.
Nobody can prove what would have happened otherwise.

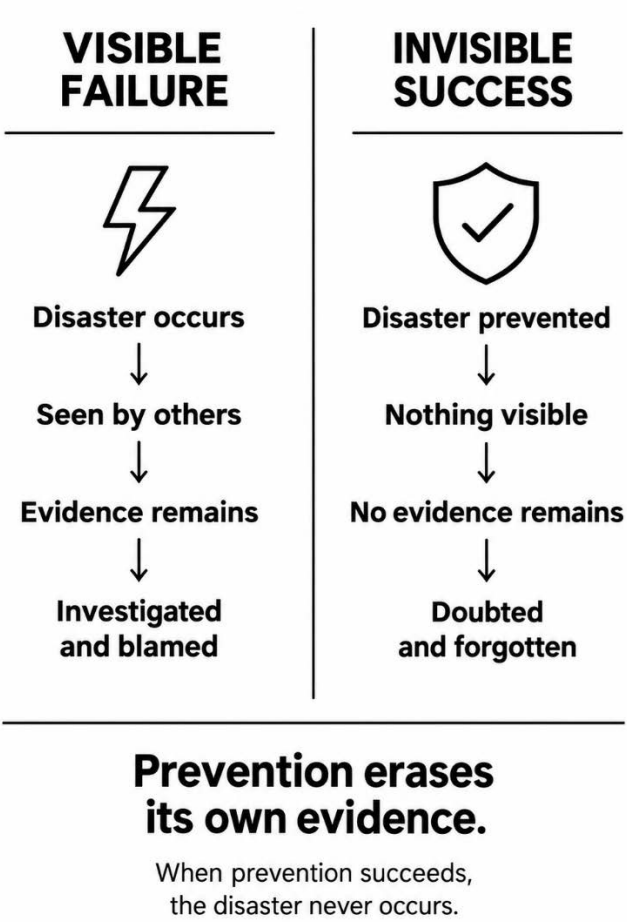
Did the intervention work?
Was the danger real?
Would nothing have happened anyway?

The evidence has disappeared.
The disaster that would have proven success never occurred.
This is one of the most important lessons life has taught me:

> *Successful prevention often erases the evidence that prevention was ever necessary.*

The paradox became easier to understand once I saw it visually.

Figure 5. Prevention Erases Its Own Evidence



Every successful prevention removes the very outcome that would have justified it. The absence of visible problems often creates the illusion that the original risk was never real, causing prevention to be undervalued until it is missing.

Selected from

Chapter Seven
The Choice Before Us

CHAPTER SEVEN

THE CHOICE BEFORE US

How do we choose our path?

Life is often described as a journey.

The image is familiar:

A single road stretching towards the horizon.

We picture ourselves walking forward, occasionally encountering crossroads where we must decide which direction to take.

Yet the longer I have lived, the less convinced I am that life resembles a single road.

Life taught me that every choice creates another branch.

The Branches of Life

Every decision creates another branch.
Some branches are immediately recognisable as life-changing.

Choosing a career.
Accepting a job.
Getting married.
Moving to another country.

Others begin quietly, almost unnoticed.

Taking another route home.
Speaking to a stranger.
Reading a particular book.
Choosing to attend an event.
Accepting an invitation.
Deciding to apologise.
Delaying a difficult conversation.

Then there are the choices that change us from within.

Choosing to forgive instead of holding on to resentment.
Speaking the truth instead of remaining silent.
Asking for help instead of struggling alone.

Choosing courage over fear.
Letting go instead of holding on.

At the time, many of these decisions feel ordinary.

Only later do we realise that they quietly altered the direction of our lives.

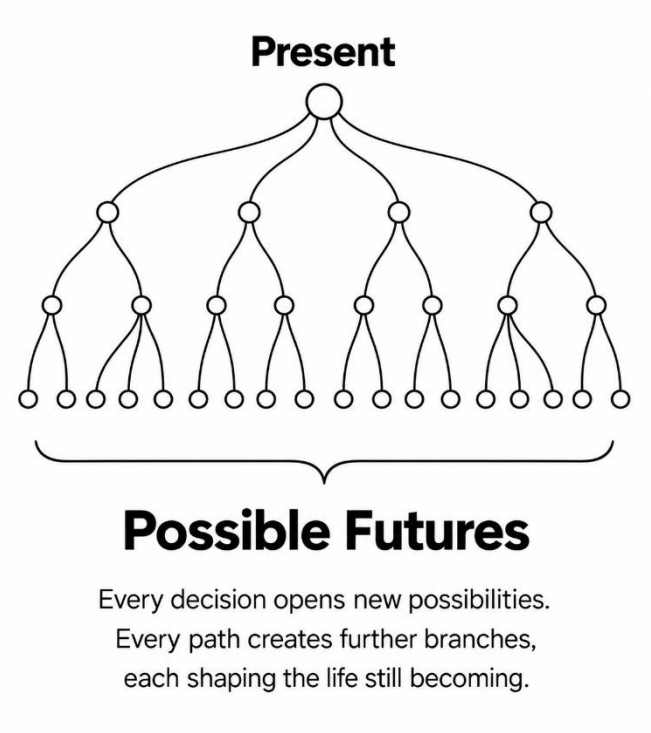
Looking back, I sometimes wonder how many versions of my life could have existed if I had made different choices.
Not because I regret the path I took.
But because every decision quietly closes countless possibilities while opening others.

Life is constantly branching.

Each new path creates new opportunities, new relationships, new challenges, and new lessons.
The branches continue to multiply in ways we could never have predicted.

It is tempting to imagine that there is one perfect path hidden somewhere among these countless branches.

Figure 11. The Branches of Life



Every decision opens some possibilities while closing others. Life unfolds not along a single predetermined path, but through countless branches shaped by the choices we make and the circumstances we encounter.

One decision that would have guaranteed happiness.
One opportunity that would have solved everything.
One mistake that ruined everything.

CHAPTER NINE

THE MEASURE OF EMOTION (情之度)

How much emotion is enough?

Most people have been told one of two things.
Some are encouraged to control their emotions.
Others are encouraged to express them.

One side praises restraint.
The other praises authenticity.

For many years, I assumed the question was whether emotions were good or bad.

Life taught me a different lesson.

The question is rarely whether an emotion exists.
The question is whether the emotion is proportionate.

Not too much.
Not too little.
But appropriate to reality.

The Problem Is Rarely Emotion

People often speak about emotions as though they are the problem.

Anger.
Fear.
Sadness.
Joy.
Pride.
Love.
Jealousy.

Yet emotions themselves are neither good nor bad.
They are information.
Signals.
Responses to how we interpret reality.

Chapter Four taught us that interpretation shapes experience.
Emotion often follows interpretation.

What matters is not merely what we feel.
What matters is whether the emotional response fits the situation.

Too Little

Imagine a person who feels no concern when a loved one is suffering.

No sadness.
No compassion.
No emotional response.

Most people would recognise something is missing.

The problem is not excessive emotion.
The problem is insufficient emotion.

Some situations deserve grief.
Some deserve concern.
Some deserve gratitude.
Some deserve love.

The absence of appropriate emotion can distort judgment just as much as emotional excess.

Too Much

Now imagine the opposite.

A minor criticism triggers overwhelming anger.
A small setback creates despair.
A delayed reply creates panic.
A disagreement becomes a personal attack.

Here the emotion exists.
But its intensity exceeds the situation.

The reaction becomes disconnected from reality.
Not because the emotion is false.
But because its measure is distorted.

Too much emotion can obscure perception.
The signal overwhelms the message.

The Invisible Ruler Returns

Chapter Two introduced the Invisible Ruler.
The same principle applies here.

Imagine another ruler.

At one end:
Too little.

At the other:
Too much.

Somewhere in the middle lies an appropriate measure.

Not a perfect measure.
Not an objective measure.
But a proportionate response.

The challenge is that most people evaluate only whether an emotion exists.

Few evaluate whether its intensity is appropriate.

Emotion as a Lens

Emotion does not merely respond to reality.
Emotion also influences how reality is perceived.

Fear highlights danger.
Anger highlights injustice.
Love highlights possibility.

A little further into the chapter...

Understanding an emotion is only part of the challenge.

The deeper question is how we respond to it.

Over time, this led me to think about emotional maturity not as suppression or indulgence, but as something else:

calibration.

Selected from

Chapter Nine

The Measure of Emotion (情之度)

The Measure of Wisdom

The older I become, the more I view emotional maturity as calibration.

Not suppression.
Not indulgence.
Calibration.

The ability to recognise:
What am I feeling?
Why am I feeling it?
Does the intensity fit reality?
What response would be most helpful?

This process does not remove emotion.
It refines it.

Much like tuning an instrument.
The goal is not silence.

It is calibration.
We do not become wiser because we feel less.
We become wiser because we respond more appropriately.

Perhaps that is why I have come to believe that...

Wisdom is measured
not by the absence of emotion,
but by the quality of our response to it.

For many years, I believed wisdom was primarily about knowledge.
The more we learn, the wiser we become.
At least that is what I once assumed.

Life gradually taught me otherwise.
I have met highly educated people who made poor decisions.
I have met intelligent people who repeatedly sabotaged themselves.
I have met knowledgeable people who lacked self-awareness.

Knowledge is valuable.
But knowledge alone is not wisdom.
Wisdom is the ability to apply knowledge appropriately.

It is knowing not only what to do, but also when, why, and how much.

Over time, I noticed that many of life's difficulties were not caused by the absence of emotion.

They were caused by excess.
Fear becomes paralysis.
Confidence becomes arrogance.
Love becomes obsession.
Generosity becomes self-neglect.
Ambition becomes greed.

Even virtues can become destructive when taken beyond their proper measure.

The problem is rarely the emotion itself.
The problem is often the degree.

As I reflected on this idea over many years, I wanted a simple way to express it.

Eventually, I settled on three Chinese characters:

情之度

The Measure of Emotion.

To me, wisdom is not the absence of emotion.
Nor is it the suppression of emotion.
Wisdom is the ability to experience emotions without becoming ruled by them.

To feel joy without becoming reckless.
To feel sadness without becoming consumed.
To feel anger without becoming destructive.

To feel fear without becoming paralysed.
To feel love without losing oneself.

Every emotion has a place.
Every emotion serves a purpose.
The challenge is finding the appropriate measure.

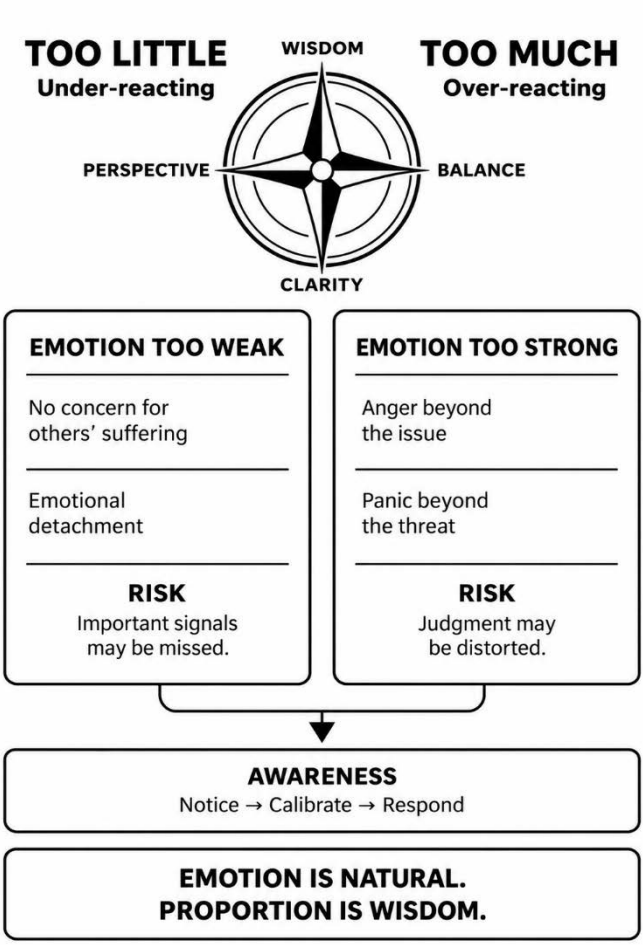
The older I become, the less I see wisdom as the pursuit of perfection.
Instead, I see it as the pursuit of balance.

Not balance in every moment.
That is impossible.
But balance across a lifetime.

Perhaps wisdom is not about becoming emotionless.
Perhaps wisdom is learning how to carry our emotions without allowing them to carry us.

That, to me, is the meaning of 情之度 (The Measure of Emotion).

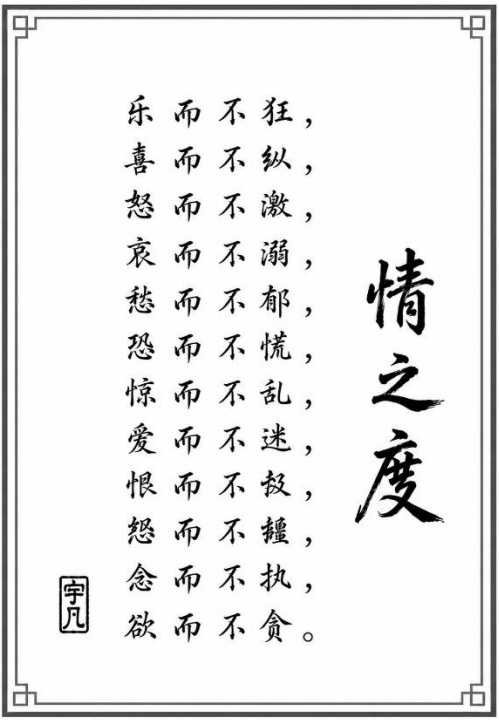
Figure 15. The Emotional Compass



Every emotion carries information, but no emotion should determine our response on its own. Like a compass, emotions provide direction rather than destination, helping us understand what matters without surrendering our judgement.

The Meaning of 情之度

Figure 16. 情之度 — The Measure of Emotion



Every emotion deserves to be acknowledged, but not every emotion should be expressed without measure. Emotional wisdom lies in responding with the appropriate emotion, in the appropriate measure, for the appropriate situation.

And finally...

The questions explored throughout this book eventually return to one larger question:

How should a life be measured?

Selected from

Chapter Thirteen

The Measure of Being

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

THE MEASURE OF BEING

How should a life be measured?

It is one of the simplest questions we can ask.
Yet perhaps one of the most difficult to answer.

For much of our lives, we inherit our measurements from other people.

Success.
Wealth.
Achievement.
Recognition.
Influence.
Possessions.
Titles.

These measurements surround us from an early age.

We celebrate good grades.
We admire successful careers.
We applaud promotions.

We congratulate wealth.
We measure progress by what can be counted.

None of these things are wrong.
Achievement deserves recognition.
Hard work deserves respect.
Success often reflects dedication and perseverance.

The question is not whether these things have value.
The question is whether they are enough.

The longer I have lived, the less convinced I have become that they are.

I have met wealthy people who remained fearful.
Successful people who remained deeply unhappy.
Intelligent people who lacked wisdom.
People with very little who possessed remarkable peace.

Life slowly taught me something I had never considered.
Perhaps we have been measuring the wrong thing.

Not because achievement is unimportant.
But because achievement was never the final measure.

Every Chapter Asked the Same Question

Looking back, I realise this book has never really been about probability.

Nor comparison.
Nor perception.
Nor cause and effect.
Nor acceptance.
Nor validation.

They were never the destination.
They were different ways of asking the same question.

How should a life be measured?

Each chapter explored a different part of life.
Yet every chapter was quietly asking a different question.

Not:
"What will happen to me?"

But:
"Who am I becoming?"

The World of Probability reminded us that uncertainty is unavoidable.

The Invisible Ruler challenged how we measure ourselves against others.

The Curse of Foreknowledge questioned how we measure our past decisions.

The Limits of Perception revealed that every person sees the world through different bubbles.

Cause and Effect reminded us that today's reality often grows from yesterday's choices.

Branches of Life showed us that every decision opens some possibilities while closing others.

The Lessons That Return taught us that life often repeats what we have not yet learned to handle differently.

The Measure of Emotion explored how our emotional responses shape our experience.

Acceptance invited us to stop fighting reality and begin working with it.

Self-Compassion asked how we speak to ourselves when we fall short.

The Measure of Worth questioned who we allow to define our worth.

At first glance, these lessons appear unrelated.

Probability.
Perception.
Choice.
Emotion.
Acceptance.
Worth.

Yet beneath them all lies a single thread.

Every lesson influences the person we become.
Every decision shapes our character.
Every response quietly leaves its mark.
Every measure eventually measures us in return.

Life is not merely happening around us.
It is quietly shaping who we are becoming.

Perhaps that has always been the greater journey.

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ABOUT THE AUTHOR



Donovan Lo is a lifelong student of people, systems, and the lessons hidden within everyday life.

Throughout his career, he has worked across technology, healthcare, social services, organisational leadership, and transformation initiatives. These experiences exposed him to a simple but enduring observation: while circumstances differ, many of the challenges people face arise from the same underlying questions about reality, choice, responsibility, emotion, acceptance, and growth.

The ideas explored in this book were not developed in a classroom or through a single field of study. They emerged gradually through lived experience, difficult conversations, personal mistakes, unexpected

opportunities, and years of observing how people make sense of the world around them.

The Measure of Being is his first book.

At its heart lies a question that has accompanied him throughout much of his life:

Who am I becoming?

He hopes the reflections within these pages encourage readers to ask the same question of themselves.

Donovan lives in Singapore.

Continue reading ***The Measure of Being*** to discover how the Invisible Ruler shapes confidence, judgement, envy, gratitude, and compassion.

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We spend much of our lives searching for certainty. Yet life rarely offers certainty. It offers probabilities, perspectives, and choices.

The Measure of Being is a collection of reflections on how we see reality, how we make decisions, how emotions shape us, and how wisdom gradually emerges through experience. Rather than offering formulas for success or promises of happiness, it invites readers to examine the invisible patterns that influence everyday life.

Through original frameworks, thoughtful illustrations, and quiet observations, Donovan LO explores topics such as perception, comparison, responsibility, acceptance, validation, and becoming. The result is not a manual for living, but a companion for thinking—one that encourages greater clarity, deeper understanding, and a more measured way of being.

Perhaps wisdom is not found in having all the answers, but in learning how to ask better questions.

INCLUDES 21 ORIGINAL CONCEPTUAL ILLUSTRATIONS THAT BRING EACH REFLECTION TO LIFE.

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Donovan Lo is a Singapore-based writer and lifelong student of people, systems, and the lessons hidden within everyday life. Drawing on experience across technology, healthcare, social services, organisational leadership, and transformation, he explores the patterns that shape how we perceive reality, make decisions, and continue becoming. The Measure of Being is his first book.

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